and I am deeply thankful to everyone for showing her that affection and respect.

Amidst all the emotion, I was actually rather surprised to see Arjun in the ground. Before I left home for the Test match we had had a lengthy discussion about whether he should watch me or play his own Under-14 match. It was eventually decided that he should go to his match. Yuvraj Singh then kindly dropped Arjun off at his game to try and make up for his disappointment at missing my 200th Test match. All of Arjun's friends were delighted to see Yuvi and Arjun was proud to be dropped off by him. Arjun's day then got even better when his team got a walkover and he jumped into a taxi and found his way to the Wankhede. He managed to convince the police of who he was and the next thing I knew was when I saw him on the giant screen, working as a ball boy.

Back in the hotel that evening, I tried to relax and enjoy the moment. I was exhausted but happy that I was still batting. I ate dinner and retired early, knowing that I had important work to do in the morning.

15 November 2013, day two of the final Test

The next day I got up at my usual time and, having finished my morning routine, put my headphones on and listened to some music. As I was walking down to the lobby and then to the bus, people wished me luck. There were happy and excited crowds on both sides of the road. I just tried to concentrate on the music and stay removed from what was happening around me. Clearly, it was not business as usual, but I did not want the enormity of the occasion to get to me.

After reaching the ground, I took out my bats and went out to the middle. It was our batting day and on such days players are allowed to follow their own routine. On fielding days, we are expected to take a few catches and do some fielding practice. Duncan said that we just needed to do a few stretching exercises and then we were on our own. I went to the nets to bat to a few throw-downs and then came back to the dressing room to get ready.

When we went out to bat I was feeling surprisingly good. Every time I took guard and saw the new bat sticker I felt a strange feeling of elation. I had always played cricket for the tricolour. Now I could see it on my bat every time I looked down. It was a terrific feeling. My mother's presence in the stands only added to my determination.